further misery to the numerous subscribers in all parts of India and outside.'[80]

To Wind Up or Not?

The question of winding up the company was therefore once again a hot topic. The public mood was of course not in favour of shutting shop. Many were aghast as news trickled out about possible liquidation.

For E. Suryanarayanaiyar of Thanjavur it was imperative that the company should function at whatever cost.[81] Noticing the term 'winding-up' in the annual report, one 'Bharatadasan' said, mixing Tamil metaphors, it ran as a stick into a wound, and a thousand thunderclaps descending on one's ears. It takes a potter many days to make pots, but it takes only a few minutes to shatter them, he said, alluding to another Tamil proverb.[82] Another correspondent, 'Na.Na.Ku.', castigating an earlier correspondent who suggested winding up, declaimed that such an action would be an insurmountable obstacle for promoting future ventures. Drawing on Hindu theology, he said that even if divine intervention was not forthcoming, the fruits of one's labour could never be lost. Such a proposal sounded like taunts by enemies and hurt badly and went to the extent of labelling him 'an anti-national'. If there were shortcomings, one should lend a hand to set things right; if not, they should at least desist from discouraging those who were striving ceaselessly.[83]

The correspondence columns of *India* were filled with letters endorsing the weekly's appeals for funds. One 'Unmaiyarivon' ('Truth-Seeker'), responding to the annual report and balance sheet, conceded that the report was an honest evaluation of the company's working and its failures and prospects. Granting that its managers may be guilty of various failings, there was no doubting their commitment and patriotism. But he took exception to the term 'winding-up'. The harm that would come to future undertakings if SSNCo was to be liquidated would be incalculable. In an emotional plea, he said, Mother India, in the form of the Swadeshi company, was tearfully beseeching her children for support. If Indians have